

The Aztecs

Starting out as a nomadic tribe, the Aztecs settled in the Valley of Mexico in the 1300s and went on to conquer a vast empire. They did not rule conquered lands directly. Instead, they forced the people to send annual tribute (payment in goods) to the Aztec capital, Tenochtitlán. The Aztecs called themselves *Mexica*, which is how Mexico got its name.

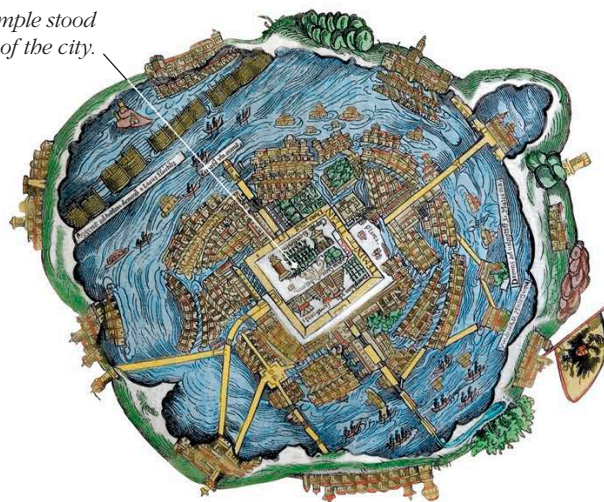
The Aztecs built Tenochtitlán on marshy islands in the middle of Lake Texcoco (in central Mexico). They created *chinampas* (plots of fertile land) on the shallow lake where they grew maize and beans.

Warfare was an important part of Aztec culture, and they fought partly for economic reasons. The tribute from captured areas supplied their city with wealth, such as jade, gold, and animal skins. War also had a religious purpose, as the Aztecs

practiced ceremonial human sacrifice. Prisoners were sacrificed to the god of war, Huitzilopochtli (Blue Hummingbird).

Between 1519 and 1521, the Aztecs were conquered by the Spanish (see pp.112–113), who built a new capital, Mexico City, on top of Tenochtitlán.

The main temple stood in the center of the city.



▲ CAPITAL CITY

Tenochtitlán was the largest city of the Americas before the arrival of Europeans. It had hundreds of temples and a palace said to have 300 rooms. The Aztecs built causeways to connect its islands to the mainland, and created a network of canals, which they navigated by canoe. The above plan of the city was made by the Spanish in 1524.

RELIGION ►

The Aztecs worshipped many gods. As farming was vitally important, they prayed to nature deities to ensure rich harvests every year. Xipe Totec (right) was the god of spring. His clothes represent the new layer of vegetation that arrives in spring.



◀ WARFARE

Most men in the Aztec Empire were trained to become ferocious warriors. They used javelins and bows and arrows as long-range weapons, and a wooden club called maquahuitl (left) for close combat. These clubs were fitted with razor-sharp blades made from a rock called obsidian along their sides.

